

GARGANO — VIESTE AND PUGNOCHIUSO

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CAP. 1 — INTRO: MY GRANDFATHER'S BEACH CLUB

My grandfather opened this beach club in 1963.

He had just bought a deck chair and an umbrella. That was it. The beach was free, the water was clean, and tourists were almost nowhere to be found.

My name is Rossella. Fifty-four years old, third generation. After my grandfather came my father, after my father came me. I raised two kids here on this beach — literally. I used to push the stroller right down to the water.

I have watched this coastline change in sixty years more than it changed in the six hundred before that. I saw the Germans arrive, then the Dutch, then Italians from the north, then the Russians, then everyone all at once. I have seen beach clubs built where there was only rock. I have seen roads cut through where there were footpaths.

But the sea has stayed the same. The same emerald green. The same white rock. The same crystal-clear water you can see straight through to the bottom.

I will tell you about Vieste the way someone who lives here year-round knows it — not just in summer.

CAP. 2 — VIESTE: THE WHITE CITY

Vieste is the easternmost city in mainland Puglia.

The old town sits on a promontory of white limestone that drops straight into the sea. On one side, Pizzomunno beach — the big one, all sand, the one you see in every photo. On the other, Castello beach — smaller, more sheltered, the one the locals prefer.

The Pizzomunno is the white rock monolith standing in front of the main beach. Sixteen metres out of the water. Legend has it he was a young fisherman turned to stone — the

sirens took him away and separated him from his beloved Cristalda. Every hundred years they meet for one night. Then he turns back to stone.

My grandmother used to tell me this story when I was little. Then you grow up and you understand it is just a legend. But every time I see the Pizzomunno at dawn, when the light has not quite arrived yet, I think of it again.

The old town of Vieste — il vicoletto, as we call it — is a maze of white alleyways, staircases, archways, terraces overlooking the sea. The Norman cathedral at the top, twelfth century, built over a pagan temple. And the Chianca Amara — the bitter stone — where in 1554 the Turks under Dragut beheaded five thousand inhabitants. Not a legend. History.

CAP. 3 — THE BEACH: WHAT THE PHOTOS DON'T SHOW

Photos of Vieste always show the same thing — a beach packed with umbrellas, green water, the Pizzomunno in the background.

It is beautiful. But it is not everything.

The coast around Vieste has thirty kilometres of beaches and rocky coves. Some reachable by car, others only on foot or by boat. The most beautiful beaches have no names on maps — only the locals know them, and people with boats.

Sciale delle Femmine, Cala Punta Lunga, Baia dei Mergoli — little white-rock coves where the water is so clear you can see the bottom three metres down. No beach umbrellas. No bars. Just the rock, the sea, and you.

I go to the beach every morning at half past six, before I open up the club. Thirty minutes for myself, in the still-cool water, with nobody around. That is my Vieste. Not the August one.

CAP. 4 — PUGNOCHIUSO: THE SECRET RESORT

Pugnochiuso is not a village.

It is a bay. A private bay, tucked between two white-rock headlands, ten kilometres south of Vieste.

In the 1960s a Milanese entrepreneur — Ovidio Presutti — bought this bay and built a holiday village here. Not just any village — a luxury resort with hotels, bungalows, restaurants, a marina. In the middle of nowhere. On a coastline that had no roads.

In the seventies and eighties, Pugnochiuso was where the important people went. Industrialists, politicians, actors. Milanese families who came south in summer and

wanted the Gargano sea without giving up comfort.

My grandfather used to deliver fresh fish there every morning. He would go up with a crate, hand it over to the chef at the main hotel, then come back. He told me it was a different world up there — people in white linen, children with sandals, aperitivo on the terrace.

The resort still exists today, changed, less exclusive than it once was. But the bay is still there — one of the finest in the Gargano, sheltered, with water that in the early morning hours turns a deep, intense emerald green.

CAP. 5 — THE SEA AT VIESTE: HOW TO REALLY SEE IT

Let me tell you how the people who know see the sea at Vieste.

By boat.

Not the motorboat with tourists lined up in rows. A small rubber dinghy, or a wooden gozzo, with a boatman who knows the coast. You set out early in the morning, follow the coast south, and go inside the caves.

Grotta Campana, Grotta delle Viole, Grotta del Diavolo — sea caves open to the water where light enters from below the surface and turns the inside electric blue. You cannot reach them on foot. Only from the sea.

Then you anchor in a cove. Swim. Eat something. Head back. That is the perfect day on the Gargano — and most tourists never do it. They stay on the beach all day and miss the best part.

CAP. 6 — VIESTE IN SUMMER AND WINTER

Vieste gets two hundred and fifty thousand visitors in August.

For a town of fourteen thousand people.

You can imagine what that means. Every cafe has a queue. Every restaurant has a waiting list. Every car park is full from nine in the morning. The sea is just as beautiful — but it is not a relaxing experience.

I love Vieste in April. When the weather is still unpredictable, sometimes raining, sometimes blazing sunshine. The sea is still cold but already green. The bars in the old town are open and there are only locals. You can find a seat. You can actually talk to people.

In winter, Vieste goes quiet. Many shops close. The seafront is empty. The north wind stirs the sea. And the town goes back to being what it always was — a place of fishermen

and traders living their own lives regardless of tourists.

CAP. 7 — WHAT TO EAT IN VIESTE

Fish. Always fish.

Vieste has a fish market early in the morning — the fishermen unload at the harbour and sell direct. If you are up by seven, you will find quality fish you would not get at any restaurant for that price.

Grilled octopus is the beach club dish. Fresh octopus, slow-grilled, with olive oil, lemon, parsley. Nothing else. Simple, perfect.

Sea urchins — if you are here between July and September. You will find them at a few spots near the harbour, cracked open on the spot, with a squeeze of lemon. Or on pasta — spaghetti ai ricci is the dish I order when I want to eat really well.

For dessert: the mostacciolo from Vieste. A hard, spiced biscuit with honey and almonds. Made at Christmas and found all year round. You dip it in wine. It is the most ancient thing you can eat here.

CAP. 8 — THE PIZZOMUNNO: THE LEGEND

The Pizzomunno is the symbol of Vieste.

A monolith of white limestone, twenty-five metres tall, standing in the middle of the beach like a sentinel. When you see it for the first time you understand why people reach for their cameras. It seems impossible — a column of white stone rising from the sea.

The legend says Pizzomunno was a young fisherman. He was in love with a girl called Cristalda — the most beautiful in the village. The sirens of the sea fell for him and tried to take him away. He refused. Out of spite, the sirens dragged Cristalda into the deep. Pizzomunno watched her disappear and turned to stone. Still there. Waiting for her.

My grandfather used to tell me this story when I was little. He would say: you see, Rossella, whoever waits too long ends up turning to rock. I still do not know if that was a warning or a promise.

CAP. 9 — THE TRABUCCHI: FISHING ON THE CLIFF EDGE

Between Vieste and Peschici the coastline changes.

No more wide, long beaches — it becomes sheer rock faces, white cliffs, the sea twenty, thirty metres below. And on those rocks, clinging like spiders, are the trabucchi.

The trabucco is an ancient fishing machine. A wooden platform jutting out over the cliff, with a system of beams and ropes that lower a net into the sea. No boat required. No strong wind needed. You wait for the fish to pass and drop the net.

The trabucchi along this stretch of coast are the most spectacular in the Gargano. At sunset, with orange light on the water, they look like silhouettes from another century. Some have been turned into restaurants — you eat right on top of them, with the sea below your feet and the net still going up every now and then.

CAP. 10 — THE OLD TOWN: THE WHITE VILLAGE

The old town of Vieste is white.

Not as a metaphor — genuinely white. The houses are whitewashed with lime, the streets are narrow, the alleyways interlock in a way that defies any description in words.

The old town stretches along a promontory reaching into the sea. On one side the harbour. On the other the beach with the Pizzomunno. At the top, the Cathedral — Romanesque, built in the eleventh century, with a crypt where the columns are Roman. Someone took them from Sipontum, the ancient Siponto. Stones get recycled in Puglia.

There is also the Chianca Amara — the bitter stone. A stone slab in the old town where enemies are said to have been executed. Until just a few decades ago, an effigy of the Turk was burned here every year. The memory of certain centuries does not fade easily.

CAP. 11 — THE HARBOUR: FISHERMEN AND TREMITI

The harbour in Vieste has two sides.

On one side the fishing boats — blue and white hulls, nets drying in the sun, stacked plastic crates, the smell of early morning sea. Vieste's fishermen go out at night and come back at dawn. The restaurants in the old town buy their fish from them.

On the other side, the ferries to the Tremiti Islands. In summer the crossings are frequent — the trip takes about an hour, depending on the boat. My grandfather used to go by motorboat, forty minutes. He said you could spot the islands from far away — three green smudges on the blue.

If you want to take the ferry to the Tremiti, leave from Vieste — it is the closest departure point. Book in advance in summer. And go early in the morning: the sea is flat and the light on the islands is something else.

CAP. 12 — THE COVES: ONLY BY BOAT

The finest things about Vieste cannot be reached on foot.

Along the coast between Vieste and the Gargano there are coves the road never touches. Small rocky inlets, clear water, not a sunshade in sight. You can only get there by boat.

In summer, rubber dinghy excursions leave from the harbour. They follow the coastline, enter the sea caves, stop in the coves. There are some — I will not name them, because the name does not change anything — where the water is such an intense green it looks unreal. You do not believe it until you are inside it.

If you have your own boat you can move freely. Renting a small dinghy without a licence is possible — ask at the harbour about the allowed engine size. It is the best way to see this coast. The way my grandfather used to do it, and the way I still do.

CAP. 13 — VIESTE AND TOURISM: A HUNDRED YEARS OF CHANGE

My grandfather used to tell me about when Vieste had three thousand inhabitants.

Fishermen, farmers, a few traders. Tourism did not exist. The roads were not paved all the way to Foggia. People were born here, lived here, died here.

Then in the sixties and seventies tourism arrived. First campsites. Then hotels. Then holiday homes. Today in August Vieste has over a hundred thousand people — thirty-five times the permanent population.

The change brought work. It brought roads, services, infrastructure. It also brought traffic, high prices, the feeling that in summer the town is no longer yours.

My grandfather used to say: before, we ate the fish we caught. Now we sell it to tourists. Is that better or worse? I still do not know how to answer him.

CAP. 14 — THE TURKS IN VIESTE: 1554

In 1554 an Ottoman fleet led by Admiral Dragut arrived off the coast of Vieste.

What happened next is still alive in this city's memory today. Thousands of inhabitants were taken prisoner and carried off as slaves. The town was ransacked. The churches, the houses, the harbour — all of it devastated.

In the old town there is a stone slab called the Chianca Amara — the bitter stone. They say that is where prisoners were counted before being loaded onto ships. I do not know how historically accurate that is — legends tend to encrust themselves over the facts with time. But the stone is there. And the memory is there.

My grandfather used to tell me: Rossella, this city is afraid of the sea. It lives off it, eats off it, makes money off it — but it does not trust it. The sea takes things away. This city knows that.

CAP. 15 — THE WHITE CLIFFS: SEEN FROM THE SEA

The coast at Vieste looks completely different from the water than from the shore.

The white cliffs — limestone, a hundred metres of vertical rock — can only be taken in fully from the water. From below, on a small boat, they look enormous. You understand why nobody ever built there. You understand the scale of this place.

The sea caves open up at the base of the cliffs. Some you can enter by boat — low and slow, timing it with the waves. Inside the echo changes. The water changes colour. The sound of the engine closes in around you.

My grandfather used to take me out on the boat from when I was five. I was not scared — I did not know what fear of the sea was. Now that I do, I respect it even more. But I keep going.

CAP. 16 — OLIVE OIL: THE GARGANO INLAND

Everyone comes to Vieste for the sea. Almost nobody goes inland.

A few kilometres from the coast — north, into the hills — there are olive groves. Old trees, twisted trunks, some of them centuries old. Gargano olive oil is recognised as a quality product — native varieties, late harvest, fruity and slightly bitter flavour.

In November, when the beach season is over, the olive harvest begins. The inland villages come alive. Families head to the groves. The oil mills open. The smell of fresh oil drifts through the streets.

This is the Gargano you do not see in summer. The one that existed for a thousand years before tourism — farming, fishing, hard work. I belong to both worlds. I was born by the sea but I know the olive trees too.

CAP. 17 — HOW TO GET THERE AND GET AROUND

Vieste is not easy to reach — and that is exactly why it is so beautiful.

By car: from Foggia, follow the state road through the Gargano — about an hour and a half. The road climbs, descends, winds — it is not a fast road. But the views along the way are worth every minute of driving.

By bus: there are connections from Foggia. Not very frequent. Extra services are added in summer. Check the timetable before you set off.

By ferry: from Manfredonia, from Bari, from Ancona. In summer there are direct links with many cities on the Adriatic coast. It is the most beautiful way to arrive — watching Vieste come closer from the sea, with the white cliffs growing on the horizon, is already an experience in itself.

Once you are there: park outside the centre and walk. The old town is pedestrianised. In summer the traffic is blocked anyway. On foot is better.

CAP. 18 — VIESTE AT NIGHT: SUMMER AFTER SIX

In summer in Vieste, after six in the evening, the town changes.

The beach tourists have showered. They are getting dressed. Between seven and ten the main street fills up — ice cream, tables outside, children running around. The air drops a few degrees — not much, but you feel it.

The restaurants in the old town open at lunch but fill up in the evening. You do not always need a reservation, but in August at the weekend it is worth booking. Eat outside when you can — the white alleyways look different at night.

My grandfather never liked summer. Too many people, he would say. But even he, in the evenings, would sit outside with a glass of white wine and watch the lively seafront. He would never admit it — but he was happy. I know because I know him. I knew him.

CAP. 19 — THE SEA CAVES: WHAT YOU SEE INSIDE

The sea caves around Vieste are among the finest in the Gargano.

You cannot see them from the shore. You cannot see them from the road. They open at the base of the cliffs, below the waterline in some cases, and you can only reach them in a low boat moving slowly.

Inside the caves the water changes colour. Light enters from below — reflected off the sandy floor — and paints the walls in sea green, turquoise, deep blue. Cut the engine, wait for your eyes to adjust. Then look up at the walls above you.

I was brought there by dinghy as a child. My grandfather always cut the engine inside the biggest cave. He would say: listen. The echo of water lapping against the walls was like music. I have never heard anything like it anywhere else.

CAP. 20 — PUGNOCHIUSO: THE STORY OF THE RESORT

Pugnochiuso is a place you do not expect.

A bay between white cliffs, reachable only by sea or through a private resort that has been there since the 1960s. Club Mediterranee opened here in 1962 — one of the first in Italy. They chose this spot because it was isolated, because the water was extraordinary, because back then nobody had yet discovered the Gargano.

The resort has changed hands but still exists. The private beach, the bungalows in the woods, the sports facilities. It is not what it once was — nothing is. But the bay is the same. The cliffs are the same. The water is the same.

Those who are not staying at the resort can reach it by boat. From out at sea, you see it set into the rocks like a gem. You understand why someone in the 1960s stopped and said: here.

CAP. 21 — CLOSING: ROSSELLA SAYS GOODBYE

Sixty years of this beach club. First my grandfather, then my father, then me.

I have watched everything change — the tourists, the prices, the fashions, the nationalities. Once they were all Italian. Then the Germans came. Then everyone.

One thing has not changed.

Early in the morning, before the club opens, before the customers arrive — there is an hour when the beach is mine. The water is flat, the sun is still low, there is no sound but the waves.

In that hour I understand why my grandfather opened a beach club here with a deck chair and an umbrella. Not to make money. To be in this place.

Enjoy Vieste. Get up early. The sea in the early morning is something else entirely.

This headland has other faces.

The trabucchi at sunset towards Peschici, the archangel's grotto carved into the rock, the islands you can see from the water on clear days, the quiet villages above Lake Varano. Each one has someone who tells its story. Someone who never left.

The Gargano does not end here.